

KELLOGG SCHOOL OF MANAGEMENT

INSIDER TIPS



ABOUT KELLOGG

The Kellogg School of Management is part of Northwestern University, located in Evanston about 12 miles north of downtown Chicago. The beautiful lakeside location in a thriving student town is a big part of the Kellogg culture, with time to cultivate strong ties with classmates that is so much part of the school's close-knit community. The collaborative learning style of the MBA program reinforces these ties, with a heavy emphasis on teamwork - 'we' rather than 'I.'

Stereo-typed as the school for marketing, Kellogg is in fact so much more. So why does McKinsey recruit more Kellogg MBAs than any other U.S. school? Because they have humility, great analytical skills, and the people skills that mean they can be client facing from day one.

STRENGTHS AND SPECIALIZATIONS

*Marketing, general management, non-profit/social responsibility,
production/operations, strategy, entrepreneurship, healthcare,
consumer goods*

KEY STATS

MBA RANKINGS*	2012	2013	2014	2015	2016	2017	2018	2019
BusinessWeek	5	5	7	3	9	9	8	10
Financial Times	9	8	9	8	11	12	8	9
Forbes	-	5	3	-	4	-	-	3
The Economist	13	15	12	6	2	-	2	3
US News	4	4	6	6	5	4	6	6

CLASS OF 2021 ADMISSIONS

Number of Applicants	3,779	Avg Age	28
MBA Class Size	474	Avg GMAT	732
Admissions selectivity	26%	Avg GPA	3.6
Yield	48%	Int'l Students	34%
Total Tuition	\$146,808	Female Students	46%

CLASS OF 2019 POST-MBA CAREERS

Consulting	31%
Technology	25%
Financial Services	19%
Consumer Products	8%

TOP RECRUITERS INCLUDE:

McKinsey, Bain, BCG, Amazon, Apple, Accenture, Google, Deloitte Consulting, Strategy&, Adobe Systems, Microsoft, Samsung Global Strategy Group, Wayfair, Oak Street Health

AVERAGE BASE SALARY: US\$128,192

EMPLOYED IN 3 MONTHS: 94%

*Rankings are relative to other U.S. business schools. [Read more](#) about the Fortuna ranking methodology.



TOP TIPS FOR ACING YOUR KELLOGG APPLICATION

BY JASON YEH

Jason is a Kellogg MBA alumnus. He draws his expertise in storytelling and the art of narrative from an unconventional career path spanning real estate development, economic consulting, music, startups, nonprofits, private equity and – most recently – analytics and storytelling lead at Nike in Portland, Oregon. He has worked in seven countries across the Middle East and Asia and traveled through 42 during his 15-year career, bringing diverse thinking and experiences to help prospective candidates gain admission to the top business schools.



Almost every aspect of the application has some component geared toward understanding if a student is the right cultural fit.

1

PLAY TO YOUR STRENGTHS...EVEN IF THEY SEEM CONVENTIONAL

Kellogg prides itself on building a truly diverse class across lots of dimensions. One of the signature traditions during orientation is for the Dean of Admissions to give a speech called “One of You” that runs down a list of remarkable highlights about new students. Admissions officers take great pride in identifying candidates who have really self-reflected on what they want and how Kellogg will get them there. The key is to embrace your genuine story even if it seems entirely normal – failing to do so trips up more applicants than you can imagine. If you’ve taken a traditional path in banking because that’s your interest, then own that. After all, an entire class can’t be filled by Peace Corps workers who started their own microfinance funds and sing professionally on the side. And if you try to spice up your application with details or stories that read falsely, officers will sniff them out immediately.

DIFFERENTIATE YOURSELF BASED ON YOUR CONVENTIONS

2

Kellogg has become so diverse that more conventional paths can stand out. This is particularly true if you’re coming from finance with plans to potentially stay in that industry or make a pivot from, say, private equity to investment banking. There is concern in some quarters that the program has embraced the poets at the expense of the quants. While this reflects a shift amongst the applicant pool (and the broader decline of interest in finance as the prestige MBA path), the school is very much attuned to applicants with a linear story and exceptional quant skills.

3

TELL A GOOD STORY

This doesn't mean embellish. Quite the opposite, the advice here is to aim for consistency in putting together your application with clear threads throughout. You definitely want to aim high, but make sure the supporting elements are solid. Do your essays and letters of recommendation define a similar vision? Do your letters of recommendation and interview paint a similar portrait? Do your undergrad experiences line up with your essays? Candidates can sometimes get a little carried away, which leads to big dreams that don't seem based in any previous experiences.

RECOGNIZE THAT CULTURE MATTERS – AND KNOW WHAT THAT MEANS

4

As the Kellogg culture has become more deeply ingrained, the need to preserve it has heightened. Officers feel a real sense of obligation to protect what makes the school unique. Almost every aspect of the application has some component geared toward understanding if a student is the right fit. So what exactly does this culture of collaboration entail? Dean Blount expresses it as impact without ego, and that's about as good a definition as exists. Another way to think about the culture is like this: the program will force you to work in team settings constantly. Most people can be dependable peers for an hour at a time. But what if you're in hour 12 of an intense case analysis? Do you still have the maturity to be just as diplomatic as in hour 1? A strong applicant will show strong situational awareness and examples of how they can work in lots of different types of teams.

5

HAVE A VIABLE ALTERNATIVE

Perhaps the most oft-cited critique or question from a Kellogg officer: “does this person have a plan b?” That’s another way of saying that the story didn’t quite come together and that the ending in particular is concerning. In the high-stakes rankings game, Kellogg has done well in large part with the employment record of a large percentage of its graduates. The careers staff do a phenomenal job in working with students, but they also don’t want to have to take unnecessary risks. To tie this all together with the other tips, if you’re plan is to start your own company but you have no entrepreneurship anywhere in your background and your recommenders say you’re risk-averse, you need to display a viable alternative. And at a school in which competition for a position in consulting is fierce, working for Bain, BCG or McKinsey in order to “round out your experiences and get exposed to lots of different industries” is not a solid backup.

ESSAY ANALYSIS

The MBA experience is only as unique as the collective contribution of the class, and this means that Kellogg is trying to uncover your capacity to lead and participate in this collective experience during school and beyond.



ESSAY 1. “Kellogg’s purpose is to educate, equip & inspire brave leaders who create lasting value. Tell us about a time you have demonstrated leadership and created lasting value. What challenges did you face, and what did you learn?” (450 words)

Let’s decode this essay, step by step.

1. “Kellogg’s purpose is to educate, equip and inspire brave leaders who create lasting value.”

To unpack the opening statement: What the question is asserting here is that walking through Kellogg’s door means that you’re not only going to receive a world-class MBA, but you’re also expected to add value by engaging in the classroom, the greater community and, ultimately, the world as a Kellogg alum. How will you drive the type of MBA experience that leaves your classmates wishing they had more time with you? The MBA experience is only as unique as the collective contribution of the class, and this means that Kellogg is trying to uncover your capacity to lead and participate in this collective experience during school and beyond.

2. “Provide a recent example where you have demonstrated leadership and created value.”

This part is directed at your specific leadership experience. Kellogg is trying to get a sense of who you are as a leader, and how you’ve shaped the organizations and communities in which you’re involved. The words to pay attention to are “created lasting value.” (This notion is so important it’s mentioned twice in the same prompt.) This is your opportunity to tell a story. Think through – why must you tell this story? How is the world better off from you having told this story? What

leadership experiences can you share that reveal you've succeeded in elevating people, places and/or circumstances because of your conscious participation? What story will illuminate the significance of this shift, showcasing the situation before you came in, while you were there and after you've left?

3. "What challenges did you face and what did you learn?"

This is both the substance and resolution of your story. Who are the characters of your story? What setting are you in? What are the stakes of you not succeeding in your leadership challenge? How did you grow through the challenge? Don't just share what you learned and stop there; essays that nail this question will also demonstrate how what you learned will translate to your unique contribution towards the Kellogg class of 2021, during your MBA and beyond.

ESSAY 2. "Values are what guide you in your life and work. What values are important to you and how have they influenced you?" (450 words)

Your values aren't a laundry list of adjectives, they're emblematic of the beliefs that guide your decisions, actions and engagement in the things that matter most to you. Similar to Stanford GSB's iconic 'what matters most to you and why' essay, Kellogg is looking to know what it is that inspires, drives and motivates you. Candidates who do the thoughtful introspection required to write with authenticity and substance will deliver a valuable view into who they are as a person, not just the inner workings of a dazzling intellect. Your values inherently extend beyond yourself, into your relationships with people and the places where you imagine making a positive impact.

This is an opportunity to tell a story that's personal, vulnerable and honest. You might lead with one specific value and the emblematic story that helps connect the dots between what has shaped you and who you've become. As you look back, what are the seminal moments, influences and interactions that have forged you into an ever-wiser human being? Has anything rocked you to the core, prompting you to rethink the path you'd charted for yourself? This can be anything from the loss of a family member to a horrible mistake or a failure that illuminated what's most essential for you.

Another tact is to lead with an origin story, the background of your childhood or the environment that shaped you. Then, how have those forces and experiences informed the person you are today and your aspirations for the future? The way to really nail this essay question is to coherently connect past, present and future. How will your values and perspectives influence the type of experience you create for your future Kellogg classmates? For the win: how will this accumulated wisdom inform the type of leader you will become in the longer term?

ESSAY 3. The Video Essay

Kellogg asks each applicant to complete a video essay component after submitting the application. This year, the school gives you all three questions upfront. The good news is you're no longer fielding an unknown question. The challenge (and opportunity) is to respond in a way that's concise, meaningful and introspective.

The first asks you to 'introduce yourself to the admissions committee' in the spirit of what you'll bring to future classmates and 'what makes you, you?'. The second drives at your career goals and 'why Kellogg.' The new third question, which speaks to your leadership potential, is asking for considerable introspection and sincerity:

"2020 has been a year of seismic disruption – fighting the global COVID-19 pandemic, tragic deaths that have brought systemic racism and social justice issues to the forefront of long overdue conversations, and economic and political divides that are growing deeper and deeper. How has this unprecedented year challenged you and how have you faced that challenge?"

Consider this video component is a huge opportunity to showcase your personality and character. As you prepare, imagine how to convey what's not obvious in your resume, credentials or LinkedIn profile. What will help make your application sticky and memorable? Again, reflect on the story you want to tell and offer a dimension that might be missing.

Play with ways to take advantage of the medium itself in your storytelling. Among my favorite efforts at a 'introduce yourself' video response was from a candidate who gave a brief viola performance, then used an element of the instrument itself as a metaphor to convey his personality and interpersonal style.

As you reflect on possible responses to the third question, consider: What meaning can be discerned from your story and what does it say about you and who you are as a leader? How might the qualities that are most important to Kellogg be reflected in your response? Considered self-reflection is the key to delivering something that's both meaningful and distinctive. As you do, keep your audience in mind – this is a business school essay after all, and your words are directed to the MBA admissions committee.

DEADLINES & DATES*

	APPLICATION DEADLINE
January 2021 Intake	2 October 2020
August 2021 - Early Decision	2 October 2020
August 2021 - Merit Fellowship	6 January 2021
August 2021 - Final Deadline	9 April 2021

***COVID-19**

For the latest updates about how COVID-19 is impacting admissions and programming at Kellogg and all top MBA programs, please visit our [blog](#).



**The best time to
apply is when you're
ready.**

Caroline Diarte Edwards,
Co-Founder & Director of Fortuna Admissions

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